

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 5

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A migrant worker describes his first day at a garment factory in a foreign country.

1

The gate of the factory was painted a tired green, and a guard waved me through it without looking at my face. I had practised, on the long bus ride, the three sentences in the local language that the agency had taught me: I am new. I am here to work. Thank you. I repeated them under my breath as I crossed the yard, the way another man might count beads. The morning sun was already biting, and the air carried a thick, oily smell that I would later learn was the smell of cloth dye and machine grease, mingled with the sweat of the previous shift.

2

Inside, the noise hit me before the heat did, and the heat was considerable. Two hundred sewing machines ran together in a long hall, each one stitching at a pace I could not, at first, follow with my eyes. Fluorescent tubes hummed overhead. A radio somewhere was playing a song I did not recognise, in a language I did not understand, and a woman near the door was laughing at something a colleague had said. The laughter, oddly, was the first thing that made me feel afraid. It was the laughter of people who belonged here, and I, plainly, did not.

3

A short man in a clean white shirt approached me with a clipboard. He must have been the supervisor. He spoke to me slowly, and when he saw that I did not follow, he spoke a little more slowly still, with no impatience in his face at all. He pointed to my chest, then to a machine three rows in. He mimed, with his hands, the action of folding a collar. He waited until I nodded. Only then did he smile — a small, polite smile that did not invite friendship but did not refuse it either — and walk away. I have thought about that smile often, in the years since. It cost him nothing, and it kept me upright.

4

The work itself was not difficult; it was simply relentless. Collar, fold, press, pass. Collar, fold, press,

pass. My fingers, which had picked rice in another country only six weeks earlier, learned the rhythm quickly. The trouble was the body around them. By the third hour, my shirt was wet through. By the fifth, my lower back had begun a steady, low complaint that I tried to ignore. The woman opposite me, perhaps forty years old, perhaps fifty, glanced at me once and pushed her own water bottle, with two fingers, an inch in my direction. She did not look up again. I drank from it, and pushed it back.

5

At noon the machines stopped, all at once, and the silence was almost as shocking as the noise had been. Workers drifted out into a small courtyard where a tin shed served rice and watery curry from large aluminium pots. I queued because everyone else queued. I held out my tray because everyone else held out theirs. The cook, a woman with a tired face and forearms like rope, ladled a portion onto my plate, and then, without explanation, ladled a second portion beside it. She did not meet my eyes. I understood, after a confused moment, that she had given me more because I was thin, and new, and obviously hungry. I almost wept into my rice. I did not, because the men around me would have seen.

6

The afternoon was longer than the morning. I cannot pretend otherwise. The heat in the hall climbed steadily, the supervisor walked the aisles with his clipboard, and once, when I let a collar slip out of alignment, he came to my station, took the piece from my hands, refolded it without a word, and placed it back on my pile. He did not scold me. He did not even shake his head. He simply showed me, again, what to do, and walked on. A small mercy, performed in passing — and I have remembered it for twenty years.

7

When the bell finally rang at six, I sat on a low wall outside the factory and watched the other workers stream past me towards the bus stop. I was too tired to stand. A boy of about my own age — perhaps Bengali, perhaps Burmese, I could not tell — slowed, looked at me, and held out, without speaking, half a packet of sweet biscuits. I took one. He took one. We ate them in silence, looking at the wall opposite. Then he nodded, once, and walked on. We never, in the months that followed, spoke more than a handful of words to each other. I do not even know his name. But that biscuit, eaten on that wall on that first evening, taught me something I have tried not to forget: that dignity, in a strange place, is something that other people — strangers, mostly — quietly hand to you, and that one day you will have to hand back to someone else.

8

I went home to the dormitory that night, lay down on a thin mattress in a room of twelve men, and slept without dreaming for the first time in a long time. In the morning, I would do it all again. But I would do it, I understood now, as one of two hundred — not as a stranger watching from outside, but as a worker among workers, holding his small place in a long, noisy line.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he repeated his three sentences “the way another man might count beads.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison tells us about his state of mind as he entered the factory. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. The narrator says that the laughter of the woman near the door “was the first thing that made me feel afraid.” Why did the laughter, rather than the heat or the noise, frighten him? [2]

3. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 2 that shows how overwhelming the factory environment was for the narrator. [1]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the supervisor’s smile as one that “did not invite friendship but did not refuse it either.” What does this phrase tell us about the supervisor’s manner? [2]

5. The narrator says of the supervisor’s smile, “It cost him nothing, and it kept me upright.” Explain the **contrast** the writer is drawing in this sentence. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes the work as “not difficult; it was simply relentless.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

7. The woman opposite “pushed her own water bottle, with two fingers, an inch in my direction.” Why do you think the writer mentions the small details of “two fingers” and “an inch”? [2]

From Paragraph 5

8. The narrator says he “almost wept into my rice” but did not. Give **one** reason from Paragraph 5 to explain why he held back his tears. [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. Explain how the language in Paragraph 6 emphasises the **quietness** of the supervisor’s kindness. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says of the biscuit, “But that biscuit, eaten on that wall on that first evening, taught me something I have tried not to forget.” What does the **repetition** of “that” achieve in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the slow disappearance of traditional crafts in modern Asia.

1

On a narrow lane in the old quarter of Varanasi, an elderly weaver sits at a wooden loom that his grandfather built before independence. The loom is, by any modern measure, absurdly slow: it takes him a fortnight to finish a single silk sari, and the price he can charge for it, even after the middleman has taken his cut, would scarcely buy a mid-range smartphone. His sons, sensibly enough, have left for the cities, where they install air-conditioners and drive ride-share cars. He does not blame them. But when he is asked, as he often is by journalists, whether the craft will outlive him, he gives a slow, tired smile and changes the subject.

2

His situation is not unusual. Across Asia, traditional crafts — handloom weaving in India, bamboo basketry in Vietnam, traditional shoemaking in Java, lacquerware in Myanmar — are vanishing at a pace that surprises even those who study them. The reasons are well known. Industrial production is faster, cheaper, and far more consistent. A power loom can produce in a day what a hand-weaver produces in a fortnight; a moulded plastic basket costs a fifth of what a woven bamboo one does. Younger artisans, for whom craft was once an inherited trade, increasingly see it as a poorly paid trap from which education is the obvious escape. The economics, on the face of it, are not subtle.

3

Governments have not been idle. In the last decade, schemes of revival have proliferated. India's "One District One Product" initiative, Vietnam's craft-village tourism programme, and Indonesia's geographical-indication labels for regional batik are only the most visible examples. These schemes offer subsidies, training, and a stamp of authenticity that, in theory, allows the genuine article to command a premium over its mass-produced imitations. The effect, however, has been uneven. Where a craft has been bound to a recognisable region — Banaras silk, Bagh prints, Hoi An lanterns — the revival has often worked. Where it has not, the schemes have at times succeeded only in producing a depressing trade in cheap "souvenir" versions, made hurriedly by people who no longer hold the older skills at all.

4

What seems to make the real difference, more often than not, is the presence of a younger generation of artisans — a generation that did not, twenty years ago, exist. These are the children of weavers and potters who left for the cities, took degrees in design or business, and then, to the bewilderment of their parents, came back. They have rebranded their family workshops, sold abroad through online platforms, collaborated with fashion houses in Tokyo and Milan, and, crucially, raised prices to a level that reflects the real labour involved. A handloom sari that fetched fifteen hundred rupees in 2010 might now, sold directly to a city customer through a curated platform, fetch six times that amount. The older artisans, watching this, are sometimes uneasy. But they are also, often, quietly proud.

5

There is also the question — and it is a difficult one — of what, exactly, is being saved. A craft is not merely an object. A handloom sari carries in its weave the memory of a specific village, a specific dye-bath, a specific family of weavers who have done this particular pattern for six generations. To replace the loom with a machine, even one that reproduces the pattern faithfully, is to lose the thing that gave the pattern its meaning. The object remains; the **story** does not. Critics of the revival schemes argue, with some force, that authenticity cannot be bottled. A "Made by Hand" label is reassuring, but it does not, by itself, restore the long, slow knowledge that is fading from these communities.

6

And yet — and this is the awkward part — craft cannot simply be preserved in a museum. To survive, it must be made, sold, and worn. Scaling it is the problem. The whole point of a hand-woven sari is that it is **not** mass-produced; the moment a workshop tries to meet large orders, the quality begins, quietly, to slip. Several well-meaning revival projects have collapsed precisely because they expanded too quickly, took on big retail contracts, and were unable to maintain standards across a hundred new weavers who had been trained in six months instead of six years. Slowness, in this trade, is not a flaw to be engineered out. It is the product.

7

The future of traditional crafts in Asia, then, is unlikely to be a simple story of triumph or of disappearance. Some crafts will fade, gently and finally, with the generation that practised them. Others will be reborn, in smaller and more deliberate forms, sustained by the curiosity of younger artisans, the patient support of governments, and the willingness of customers to pay a fair price for what is, in the end, more than an object. What is at stake is not nostalgia. It is a question of whether we are content to live in a world in which everything we touch was made, in haste, by someone we will never see — or whether, somewhere in the corners of our lives, we still want the slow, the difficult, and the quietly remembered.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says of the weaver, “He does not blame them.” What is the writer’s **attitude** towards the weaver in this sentence? [1]

13. What does the weaver’s response — “a slow, tired smile” and changing the subject — suggest about his view of the craft’s future? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why traditional crafts are losing out to industrial production. [2]

15. The writer says, “The economics, on the face of it, are not subtle.” Explain the writer’s choice of the phrase **on the face of it**. [2]

From Paragraph 3

16. Why does the writer place the word “souvenir” in inverted commas in Paragraph 3? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that the older artisans are “sometimes uneasy” yet “often quietly proud” of the returning younger artisans. Explain, in your own words, the **contrast** the writer is drawing here. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer claims that “the object remains; the **story** does not.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

19. What is the **tone** of the phrase “authenticity cannot be bottled”? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says, “Slowness, in this trade, is not a flaw to be engineered out. It is the product.” Explain why the writer presents these as **two short sentences** rather than one. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. In the final paragraph, the writer asks whether we are “content to live in a world in which everything we touch was made, in haste, by someone we will never see.” What is **effective** about ending the article with this question? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why traditional crafts in Asia are declining**, and **what is being done to save them**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 4** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Traditional crafts in Asia are declining because ...

— END OF PAPER —